

"The Extraordinary Gene"

Getting beyond being just another mammal

(Based on Likkutei Toraj, Netzavim, d'h Sos Osis, 47a)

❖ Synopsis

Why was Rosh Hashana established to be on the sixth day of the Six Days of Creation, and not on the first day? Why were all our matriarchs' barren women, in need of a miracle to bear children?

Why did G-d, after making a covenant with Noah, go on to make a covenant with Abraham, and then again with Moses? Understanding the secret of the human being, being far beyond just another mammal.

❖ Milsa D'bechuso

• *I Like the Way I Look!*

I knew a man by the name of Donny K. whose wife was quite concerned with his health and his being overweight. Nu, Donny disagreed to go to what he called a *Fat Farm*, made for those overweight in need of losing weight. Donny returns after the extended time of the program, glowing and smiling, but with out a pound shed. I asked him what had happened, and this is what he told me:

"The first day we got there, we were gathered in the social hall, where we were given a pep talk. The facilitator told us that when we went into our bathroom that night to take a shower, we should notice the full-length mirror hanging on the door. Just before we entered the shower, we should look at ourselves from head to toe and say, 'I don't like the way I look'"

"Well, I did look into the mirror at my body, and I said, 'Donny, I like the way you look!'"

And Donny went on to confirm to me that he truly enjoyed his eating, and that he truly liked the way he looked. And with this I gleaned a far deeper understanding to Jim Collin's opening premise to his book *From Good to Great*, "*The greatest enemy of great is good.*"

A yet less amusing way to see this is through the *Frog Experiment*, in which science has observed that a frog --being a cold-blooded creature, with the power to continuously adjust its body's temperature to that of its environment-- when placed into a pot of water on a low flame, slowly getting hotter and hotter, the frog will continue to raise its own body temperature until it will cook itself, while when placed into a hot pot of water will just immediately jump out.

And yet, both stories are one and the same, in which the gift of adjusting, evolving and accepting turns from gift to vice, and sometimes a fatal one indeed.

Rosh Hashanah is the day of the year, in which we rise on up and out of being but a mammal in an environment of mammals, and of defined beings trapped within the genetics and innate drives of the science in which we were created.

❖ The Covenants

• Questions

Let us begin with two questions:

- (i) Our sages teach us that the holiday of Rosh Hashanah, commemorating the first day of the Jewish year, based upon the genesis of it all, in the *Six Days of Creation*, is actually not set upon the first day of creation, but on the sixth day of creation. In other words, day one of the sixth days of creation is actually five days ago, on the 25th day of the month of Elul in the Jewish calendar.

Today, Rosh Hashanah, which is the 1st day of the month of Tishrei, actually coincides with the sixth day of the *Six Days of Creation*, in which Adam and Eve were created. Hence, the question of why is this so, and especially since *Rosh Hashanah* is as we say in the *Rosh Hashanah Musaf Services* (-based upon the Talmud, Rosh Hashanah 27a), "*This day is the beginning of Your works, a commemoration of the first day.*" And yet, even in this statement, we find that on the one hand it is, "*This day is the beginning of Your works,*" while on the other hand, it is only, "*a commemoration of the first day.*" So, something about this sixth day of creation in which Adam and Eve were created, while being only a commemoration of the first day, nevertheless, it is the embodiment of the beginning of Your works.

- (ii) Every single one of our four matriarchs were barren. Sarah didn't conceive until the age of 90, when the three angels visited Abraham and brought G-d's promise and blessing that next year at that precise time, they would have a child. Rebecca, after twenty years of not having a child, her and Isaac pray for a miracle, and only then does Rebecca conceive. Rachel goes through barrenness, demanding of Jacob to pray for her, brings her maid to Jacob, so that through her given her maid a chance to have children, that she be blessed with children, and only then does Rachel conceive. And even Leah, who does get pregnant right away, the verse makes sure to let us know that this was only because of, "*And the L-rd saw that Leah was hated, so He opened her womb.*" Meaning that otherwise, Leah too was meant to be barren! Why?!

- Mother Nature

Looking into the *Six Days of Creation*, we find that G-d created a self-sustaining system. Even the Garden of Eden was created so that, "*And a mist ascended from the earth and watered the entire surface of the ground,*" "*And the L-rd G-d planted a garden in Eden,*" "*And the L-rd G-d caused to sprout from the ground every tree pleasant to see and good to eat,*" and, "*And a river flowed out of Eden to water the garden.*" So much so, that the sages felt obliged to take the verse, "*Now the L-rd G-d took the man, and He placed him in the Garden of Eden to work it and to guard it,*" out of its simple text, for there was no need to work it, and neither was there from who and what it needed to be guarded. Hence, the sages are obliged to explain that the work and the guarding refers to the spiritual sense of working the 248 mitzvot and guarding the 365 prohibitions.

And quickly, trouble on the ranch began, as Adam ate from the Tree of Knowledge, and now the, "*to work it and to guard it,*" meant, "*Cursed be the ground for your sake; with toil shall you eat of it all the days of your life... with the sweat of your face you shall eat bread.*" But, nevertheless, the self-sustaining system, in essence, was still working, only that man with his sin had caused interference, and now the, "*And it will cause thorns and thistles to grow for you,*" needs to be removed by man's labor.

Total turbulence begins when the generation of Noah brings total corruption to the world, and now, not only did G-d eliminate all of the creatures of *Mother Nature*, but *Mother Nature* herself was disrupted, as our sages tell us, "*They [the laws of Mother Nature] ceased for the duration of the Flood: the planets did not function, and day was indistinguishable from night.*" And hence, post-flood, there was the need for G-d to make a covenant with Noah, a covenant with *Mother Nature*, that, "*And I will no longer smite all living things as I have done. So long as the earth exists, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, and day and night shall not cease.*"

The point here being, that G-d created the world in a self-sustaining fashion, mankind, through sin, interfered with this self-sustaining system, mankind went so far to cause a complete shutdown to this self-sustaining system, and G-d swore that he would never allow mankind to do that again.

In the language of Kabbalah and Chassidus, the system that G-d put in place with the *Six Days of Creation* is that of, "*He renews in His goodness every day, continuously, the works of creation.*" Meaning, that on a deeper level, the self-sustaining system, and its reestablishment with the covenant to Noah, is actually on a spiritual level as well, that G-d is continuously recreating and vivifying creation from *ex nihilo*.

Hence, this self-sustaining system of the creation of the universe does not need a *Rosh Hashanah*, for in each and every day it is self-sustainingly being recreated, without the need of the Jew sounding the shofar.

- *Cinderella Man*

Cinderella Man is a 2005 American biographical sports drama film directed by Ron Howard, titled after the nickname of world heavyweight boxing champion James J. Braddock and inspired by his life story. It takes place in the times of the *Great Depression*, and is a beautiful story of endurance, survival and success. There is a single line in the film that I wish to draw your attention to. Braddock's friend and agent, Joe Guild, meets with the big wigs of *Maddison Square Garden*, trying to get Braddock a fight, and the agent blurts out, "Oh come one, have a heart!," to which the big wig *macher* gets very serious and answers, "My heart and soul I have at home, for my wife and kids, while to the office I bring my brains and brazenness."

This wasn't shouted or said in anger, but just factually, and in a *station identification* mode, of understanding who, what and where things are to stand in one's life.

"*Brains and Brazenness*," are but the exterior tools of the person, while our, "*Heart and Soul*," are our essence, and when one says that their *Heart and Soul* is invested into someone or something, they are saying that here is where their essence lies.

And now let us take a look at what uniquely took place on the sixth day of creation:

- Living Creatures

Concerning all the other creatures, G-d had uttered, "*Let the waters swarm a swarming of living creatures*," and, "*Let the earth bring forth living creatures*." However, concerning the human being, the verse states that G-d formed the body from the earth, and seemingly it lay there lifeless until, "*and He breathed into his nostrils the soul of life*," and only then, "*and man became a living soul*." However, the holy *Orach Chaim* teaches that Adam too, before G-d breathed into his nostrils the soul of life, was a living creature. And that the soul of life which G-d breathed into his nostrils was not the life force of Adam's body, but rather, it was the *Intellectual Soul*, which only the human being was gifted with. Chassidus refers to it as the *G-dly Soul*, which is, "*Truly a piece of G-d Above*."

In other words, the life force of all living creatures, which we loosely refer to as the soul of the creature, from a Torah perspective, is not spirituality nor a spiritual being. Rather, it is the *physical* life force of the body. So much so, that it is precisely defined as the *mist* (steam; oxygen) within the blood. What was created *only* on the sixth day of creation, was a true spiritual being, the *soul of life* of the human, which refers not to the life force of the body of Adam, but to a spirituality, of which G-d describes as, "*Let us make mankind in our likeness and our image*," and, "*or man was created in the image of G-d*."

This is neither part of *Mother Nature*, nor art of the *Covenant with Noah*. Likewise, this is not part of the *self-sustaining system* of, "*He renews in His goodness every day, continuously, the works of creation*." For this *Spiritual Being*, there must be a *Rosh Hashanah*, with the essence connection of the outcry of our soul, through the purest sound of the *Shofar*, with which we cry out to G-d, "*Our G-d and G-d of our fathers, reign over the entire world with Your glory!*"

- Covenant with the Barren

With this we now understand the covenant that G-d made with Abraham, and ultimately with our barren matriarchs that they have children:

"On that day, the L-rd formed a covenant with Abram, saying, "*To your seed I have given this land*."

The covenant was made with Abraham before he had and seed, and hence, the covenant includes (i) that Abraham, the first Jew, will have children, and create the Jewish nation, and that, (ii) to the seed of Abraham will G-d give the land. And hence, in this covenant, we have the secret of the verse, "(i) *This day is the beginning of Your works*, (ii) *a commemoration of the first day*."

Every human being was simply mating and having offspring, ever animal, insect, fowl and fish were mating and having offspring, and for the majority, with no difficulties at all. For, they all were part of the self-sustaining system and the *Covenant of Noah* that G-d made with *Mother Nature*. However, Sarah, Rebecca, Rachel and Leah were to begin the lineage of the *Sixth Day of Creation*, the, "*And He breathed into his nostrils the soul of life*," as G-d said, "*And Abraham will become a great and powerful nation, and*

all the nations of the world will be blessed in him. For I have known him because he commands his sons and his household after him, that they should keep the way of the L-rd to perform righteousness and justice."

For this lineage, there has been no covenant with G-d yet, nor was there any establishment of a self-sustaining system in place. Hence, the barrenness of each and every one of our matriarchs, demanding a conscious and direct connection with G-d, forging a direct intervention by G-d. No, G-d would not allow for Sarah, Rebecca, Rachel or Leah to just believe that they too, as any other human, mammal or creature, is just fulfilling the promise of *Mother Nature* to be fruitful and to continue on. No! This was *Rosh Hashanah* in the making, this was the truest "*beginning of Your works*, through which there was the, "*commemoration* (fulfillment of purpose) *of the first day*."

- Covenant with the Sinner

But Alas, are we then not human, driven by the same instincts, hormones, chemicals and needs of the mammals? How are to always live in the *Higher Reality* that we are, "*Divine Beings having human experiences*," without succumbing to the *Lower Reality* of being but a rat surviving in a rat race?! We are mortal, fallible and sincerely fragile, scripted for sin...

Hence, G-d makes yet another covenant, and this time through Moses with the Jewish people. And this covenant is ultimately G-d's covenant with the sinner, promising that the ultimate Divine power of *Teshuvah* shall never return empty-handed. And hence, *Rosh Hashanah* now becomes the ultimate experience of the creature with the *Spiritual Being* within him, commencing the *Ten Days of Teshuvah* culminating with the intimacy of *Yom Kippur* and the sealing within the *Book of Life* for a good and sweet year.

❖ In Closing

- *Be Extraordinary!*

In closing, *Rosh Hashanah* is not the day to ask just for life, but for an **extraordinary** life! For, the ordinary life needs not a *Rosh Hashanah*, but rather, just to follow the advice of *Dora* in *Finding Nemo*, to, "*Just keep swimming... just keep swimming...*"

Rosh Hashanah is specifically for the life of, "*and He breathed into his nostrils the soul of life*," for those who are willing to be **extraordinary**, in being a *Divine Being having a human experience*.

But, practically speaking, how does one live an extraordinary life?! And maybe we need to give up on this egotistical drive of being extraordinary, and to better accept just being successful and being ordinary?! And, where can I find any proof or definition as to in what I am extraordinary?!

Turn to *Covenant of Moses*, which we defined today as ultimately being G-d's covenant with the sinner. You want to know in where and what you are extraordinary? Then take a look at your sins, my friend. That's right, looking at your sins, and see to where you gravitate, left alone to your own devices. Our sins are our extraordinary gifts gone haywire. And hence, our being extraordinary lay in our embracing our sins and the hidden beauty of self within them. Our being extraordinary is our not hiding our sins, but in doing *Teshuvah* with our sins.

And I leave you now with two stories:

Story One:

The king had a most precious diamond, perfect in color, shape and brilliance. One day, in total devastation, the king noticed that there is a scratch in the diamond. Beside himself in anguish, the king let it be known that for anyone who can fix the diamond, he will reward him with a lifetime of riches. However! If by doing so, the person will diminish the size or brilliance of the diamond, the person shall pay with his life.

No one dared to take on the challenge. One person did. After the allotted time for him to return the diamond, restored to perfection, to the king, the person arrived and handed back the diamond

to the king. The king looked and saw that what the person did, was that he turned the scratch into the stem of a most beautifully engraved rose, which then created an unprecedented shine and prism reflections from the diamond. The king looked at the man and said, *"Perfectly well done! You shall be rewarded as promised."*

Yes, G-d wants not our perfect stone, as He created us. That it but G-d being perfect. G-d wants our extraordinary gene, with which we take our very sins, and from it bring forth our being spectacularly extraordinary.

Story Two:

A man came to Rabbi Levy Yitzchok of Berditchev, crying bitterly, *"Rebbe, you must teach me how to do Teshuvah!"*

To which Reb Levy Yitzchok responded, *"But, who taught you how to sin?"*

To which the man responded, *"Rebbe, no one taught me how to sin. That, I figured out by myself!"*

To which, Reb Lev Yitzchok responded, *"Nu, so now go figure out by yourself how to do Teshuvah!"*

Reb Levy Yitzchok was a Rebbe and a Lover of Jews par excellence. No, Reb Levy Yitzchok was not being harsh or unhelpful to the Jew who came to him asking to be helped in doing *Teshuva*. Rather, Reb Yitzchok was telling the person, *"Make your Teshuvah extraordinary! Be who you alone are meant to be! Go to that very extraordinary place within you, where you learned how to sin, for from there alone you will find your Teshuvah and how extraordinary you were, are and always will be!"*

This my friends, is the secret of the *Shofar*. It's not a brilliant piece of words, nor even a brilliant quote of the Torah. Rather, it is an outcry from the extraordinary place within us, in which we learned how to sin, and with which we now do *Teshuvah*.

L'Shana Tova!